CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

UX RESEARCHER IN THE AI ERA

The researchers still standing are the ones in the strategy meeting. The ones who took notes are being replaced by the tool that takes notes.

★ TL;DR — Our take: NO — not as a 2027 start. There is no BLS occupation for this title, and the market median that looks so good (~$110K) is paid to seniors. The beginner layer — recruiting, transcription, tagging, first-pass synthesis — is exactly what AI research tools now do, and the biggest employers are cutting the function itself. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

OUR TAKE: NO — NOT IN 2027

MEDIAN ~$110K · TRAINING 1–2 years · AI RISK MEDIUM · CERTIFICATE

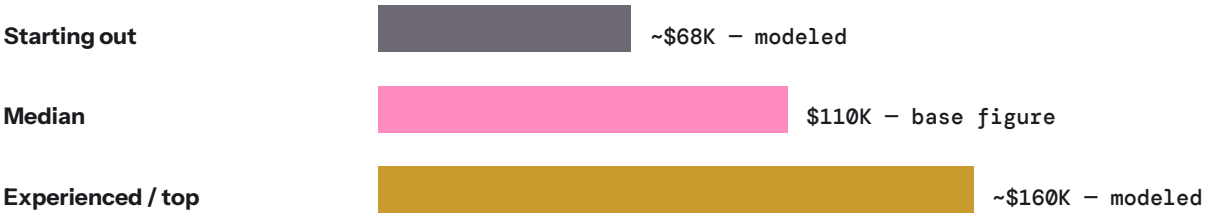
- The pay is real and unreachable: market medians run ~$110–123K (Robert Half's matched-placement median is $123,000) — for experienced researchers. Entry bands sit far below, and the entry jobs are the ones disappearing.

- The cuts are named, not rumored: in October 2025 Google cut 100+ design and UX research roles in its Cloud division, with quantitative UXR teams reduced by up to half, explicitly to fund AI infrastructure.

- The profession's own data closes the case: Nielsen Norman Group's October 2026 survey found AI saves time on nearly every artifact task — transcription, tagging, synthesis, first-pass analysis — the junior researcher's exact task list, and researchers were the UX group most likely to expect their role to shrink.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for UX Researcher is a ~$110K median (compiled from U.S. labor-market data (this title has no separate BLS occupation; the figure is a market/anchor estimate)). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A UX RESEARCHER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Design interview, usability and survey studies tied to product decisions
- ✓ Recruit participants and run sessions without leading the answers
- ✓ Synthesize transcripts, tags and data into findings teams act on
- ✓ Defend evidence and uncertainty in rooms that would rather guess

Think: a detective for why users say one thing and do another — except the evidence-clerk half of the job just got automated, and only the courtroom half still hires.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Transcription, tagging, theme-spotting, survey summarization and first-pass synthesis. Nielsen Norman Group measured the gains landing precisely on the junior task list — the work beginners used to be hired, and trained, to do.	Research that changes a roadmap decision: mixed-methods judgment, quant work at scale, and persuading stakeholders to act on unwelcome evidence. That residue survives — and it is hired at senior level, from inside product organizations.

⚠ **The ladder is collapsing, not just the bottom rung. The profession's own analysts describe dedicated teams being dissolved into product roles and the junior-to-senior path closing. A certificate aimed at a ladder that no longer reaches the ground floor is an expensive souvenir.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ The surviving craft is genuinely interesting: evidence over opinion ✓ Research skill transfers — every door below pays for it ✓ Senior researchers are well paid and hard to replace	✗ No official occupation, no official growth series — the title lives on market data alone ✗ The biggest employer class is publicly shrinking the function ✗ Beginner postings are the scarcest they've ever been

Good fit? Already inside a product org — support, design, analytics, operations — with real user problems in front of you and years of context. For you, research is a sideways move upward, not an entry.

Bad fit? Anyone buying a UX research bootcamp in 2027 as a first door into tech. The door the course points at is the one Google just closed.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — PIVOT TO Market Researcher	DOOR B — PIVOT TO Data Analyst
Same craft, commercial side, official numbers: BLS Market Research Analysts median $78,760, growth +7% — faster than average. Companies still hire juniors here because the research feeds revenue decisions directly, and the methods stack transfers almost whole: study design, sampling, survey craft, synthesis, presenting evidence to people who'd rather guess. First move: rebuild one UX study as a market study — a pricing, demand or competitor question with a business owner attached — and put the decision it changed on page one.	The quantitative half of research, priced honestly: there is no BLS occupation for data analysts either — the parent occupation, Data Scientists, medians $120,230 with +35% growth, and entry-level analyst pay starts well below that. Say so on your own roadmap before an employer does. The bridge: quant UXR already runs surveys, funnels and behavioral data; add SQL and one BI tool and the same evidence brain sells into a growing occupation instead of a shrinking title.

Smart move: Don't collect methods — collect decisions. One study that changed what a business actually did (a price, a launch, a roadmap) is the asset every surviving research role, on either side of these doors, is hired for.

Where you land after: You land where evidence is bought: a market research role with real growth under it, or an analyst seat on the quant side — with the research judgment the pure quants don't have.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
READ THE	REBUILD YOUR	QUANT LITERACY,	RUN A	BUILD THE	APPLY WHERE

STEP 1 — Read the verdict like an adult

TODAY · FREE

- Look at the actual entry postings for UX researcher this week and count the years of experience they demand.
- Write down which of your target tasks AI tools already perform — be specific, not hopeful.

STEP 2 — Rebuild your craft as commercial research

WEEKS 1-4

- Study how market research frames questions: demand, pricing, segmentation, competitors.
- Take one past UX study and rewrite its findings as a business decision memo.

STEP 3 — Quant literacy, for real this time

MONTHS 1-2

- Survey statistics, sampling error and significance — the math juniors used to skip.
- Learn one analysis tool properly (even advanced spreadsheet work counts) and show your workings.

STEP 4 — Run a decision study for a real business

MONTHS 2-3

- Find a local business, nonprofit or indie product with a pricing or demand question.
- Run the study end to end and document the before-and-after decision.

STEP 5 — Build the portfolio around outcomes

MONTHS 3-4

- Each case: the question, the method, the evidence, the decision it changed.
- Cut any case study that ends in 'insights' instead of an action.

STEP 6 — Apply where the growth is

MONTHS 4-6

- Target market research analyst and junior analyst postings; lead with the decision portfolio.
- In interviews, sell judgment under uncertainty — the layer the tools demonstrably don't cover.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: count the experience requirements on ten real UX researcher postings. That number is the verdict.

□ Days 1–30: reframe your craft commercially — rewrite one study as a business decision memo and learn the market-research question types.

□ Days 31–60: quant fundamentals plus one real decision study underway for a real business.

□ Days 61–90: portfolio rebuilt around decisions changed; applications out to market research and analyst roles.

□ Day 90: you're a researcher with commercial proof and a growing occupation under you — not a bootcamp graduate queuing at a closed door.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **EVIDENCE PAYS. NOTE-TAKING DOESN'T.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. labor-market data (this title has no separate BLS occupation; the figure is a market/anchor estimate)). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.